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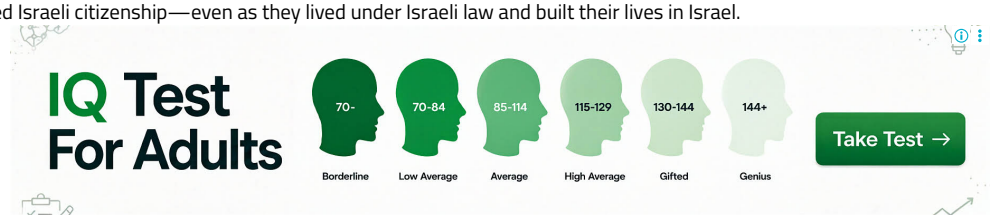
From Syria's Shadow To Israel's Side: The Golan Druze Make A Historic Choice



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 26, 2026

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For generations, many Druze living on the Golan Heights kept their eyes fixed across the border. They spoke of Syria as their homeland, maintained family ties there and resisted Israeli citizenship—even as they lived under Israeli law and built their lives in Israel.



The Druze are a distinct religious community whose faith emerged in the 11th century. Around a million Druze live across the Middle East, especially in Syria, Lebanon and Israel. Their religion does not accept converts, and their communities have historically been closely tied to the countries where they live. That makes the changing relationship between the Golan Druze and Israel a remarkable shift in both identity and political future.

Israel's Interior Ministry recorded 3,750 citizenship applications from Golan Druze in 2025, compared with roughly 500 to 600 a year before the surge. In just the first two months of 2026, nearly 1,000 more residents completed naturalization. In Majdal Shams, the Golan's largest Druze town, about 38 percent of residents have now become Israeli citizens.

These are more than numbers on government forms. They mark a historic shift in how many Golan Druze see their future—and whom they believe they can depend on when danger comes.

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The Soccer Field That Changed Everything

האוסף שנשמר 50 שנה
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פתח

On July 27, 2024, a Hezbollah rocket struck a soccer field in Majdal Shams, killing 12 Druze children. They were playing in their own town, far from any battlefield, when a terror group's attack turned an ordinary evening into a national tragedy.

For many residents, the massacre carried a bitter message. Hezbollah, an Iranian-backed force that had fought alongside Syria's Assad regime, had brought death to the Golan Druze. The border that once represented their connection to Syria could not shield them from the violence surrounding it.

Then Assad fell in December 2024. At first, some Golan Druze welcomed the end of his rule and hoped a new Syria might offer a better future. But that hope was shattered the following summer.

In July 2025, brutal violence engulfed Sweida, a largely Druze province in southern Syria. Druze civilians were killed, homes and businesses were destroyed, and fears about the community's safety under Syria's new rulers deepened. Golan residents watched as their relatives and fellow Druze across the border faced the very danger they had hoped Syria's transformation would end.

A Choice Made Under Pressure

For decades, many Golan Druze avoided Israeli citizenship out of loyalty to Syria, hope that the Golan might one day return to Syrian rule, and concern for relatives across the border. Citizenship could be viewed locally as a rejection of that identity. Some who applied risked social pressure or estrangement.

That history makes the recent surge especially significant. The choice is not simply about passports. It reflects a growing conviction that the state governing their lives—and the one capable of protecting them—is Israel.

The shift does not mean every Druze resident has abandoned a Syrian identity or cut ties with relatives across the border. The community remains diverse, and families do not all see citizenship the same way. But the old assumption that Syria would ultimately be their political home has lost much of its force.

Israel's response during the Sweida crisis also mattered. As reports of attacks on Druze civilians spread, Israel intervened and delivered aid. Many Golan Druze saw that as more than a strategic gesture. They saw a state willing to act when their community faced a threat.

The bond has also been tested through military service and sacrifice. In March 2026, Sgt. First Class Maher Khatar of Majdal Shams was killed while serving in the IDF in Lebanon. His death was reported as the first time a soldier from his town had fallen in combat. For a community whose relationship with Israel had long been complicated, that loss carried profound meaning.

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Why This Matters To Israel

A larger number of Golan Druze citizens means more residents can take part in Israel's national elections and civic life. Their votes could give the four Druze towns a stronger voice on local services, education, tourism and economic development. It also deepens the connection between Israel and a community that sits on a strategically important frontier.

But the implications reach beyond voting. Israel has long described itself as a protector of the Druze, including the Druze citizens who serve in its military. The Golan's changing relationship with Israel puts that promise to a serious test. Trust will depend not only on protection during a crisis, but also on whether residents feel respected, heard and supported in daily life.

A historic shift in citizenship brings opportunity and responsibility. If Israel welcomes these new citizens as full members of the country, it must show that their communities have a real stake in its future.

A Claim That Could Become A Flashpoint

Syria's new leader, Ahmed al-Sharaa, has repeatedly reaffirmed Damascus's claim to the Golan Heights. He has said Syria seeks to regain the territory through negotiations and has declared that the Golan remains Syrian. His statements do not mean war is imminent. But they make clear that the territory's future remains a point of dispute between the two countries.

That dispute gives the Druze shift added importance. If tensions over the Golan deepen, the residents most directly affected will not be distant observers. They are becoming Israeli citizens, taking part in Israel's elections, and—in some cases—serving in its military. Many are also tied by family and faith to Druze communities across the Syrian border.

The idea that the Golan Druze will simply stand between Syria and Israel, waiting for the future to be decided for them, is becoming harder to imagine. More are choosing to tie their civic future to Israel, even as they carry a complicated history and family connections across the border.

A Signal Across The Middle East

The Golan Druze story is also a warning about the region's instability. Syria's future will be shaped in part by whether its new authorities can protect minorities and prevent sectarian violence. When communities fear that their identity makes them a target, promises of national unity ring hollow.

It also underscores how closely Israel's security is tied to the fate of the communities along its borders. Hezbollah's rocket attack on children and the violence in Sweida showed how quickly regional instability can reach ordinary families. Israel's actions toward the Druze will influence how neighboring communities judge its intentions—and whether they see it as a possible protector.

The Golan Druze are not making this choice from a position of comfort. They are responding to grief, fear and the collapse of assumptions that shaped their community for generations. Yet thousands are now choosing a deeper civic connection to Israel.

ted their past and, for many, the hope of a future reunion. Today, more Golan Druze are looking to Israel for security, opportunity and a place in the country where they live.

That is a historic choice. If conflict over the Golan ever returns, it may also shape who stands where.

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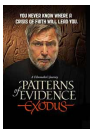


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